NEFA. Complicating matters even further, since 1985 China has extended its claim to include a demand for territorial concessions in the Tawang area. India perceives this as part of a broader encirclement strategy, which includes inroads into Bhutan, and would make India more vulnerable than it already is.[33]

In October 2014, Narendra Modi's new government announced a plan to build 2,000 kilometres of new roads in Arunachal to improve its infrastructure and help develop remote, neglected areas in the state. The government also pledged to allocate more resources to build schools, clinics, and bridges, and to improve telecommunications. The Indian minister of State for Home Affairs, Kiren Rijiju, who is a native of Arunachal, later told *Bloomberg* that 'the people along the border have migrated down where amenities are available. People native to the region should not have to move out.'[34] None of the roads, however, would link the state with China. 'I don't want to link it with China,' Rijiju told *Bloomberg*. 'We are not doing anything to disturb relations. It's not in terms of challenging or competing with China, but in terms of securing our own territory.'[35]

The Chinese authorities reacted immediately to India's plans. On 14 October, Chinese foreign ministry spokesman Hong Lie said, 'We still need to verify the specifics. The boundary issue between China and India is left by colonial past. We need to deal with this issue properly … Before final settlement is reached we hope that India will not take any action that may further complicate the situation.'[36]

In February 2015, after Modi paid a visit to Arunachal's state capital, Itanagar, Chinese Vice-Foreign Minister Liu Zhenmin said that 'the Chinese government has never recognised the so-called "Arunachal Pradesh" unilaterally set up by the Indian side'.[37] The official Chinese news agency *Xinhua* reported in the same vein, 'The so-called "Arunachal Pradesh" was established largely on the three areas of China's Tibet—Monyul, Loyul and Lower Tsayul, currently under Indian illegal occupation. These three areas, located between the illegal "McMahon Line" and the traditional customary boundary between China and India, have always been Chinese territory.'[38]

Even if the rhetoric these days is not quite as gross and bombastic as it was in the 1950s and 1960s, the Chinese position remains the same and, in